

The Firefly Lanterns

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



The Firefly Lanterns

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

Tonight was the night of the summer Lantern Festival, the warmest night of all the year in the Lantern Village. Every summer the paper lanterns came alive with light, and the whole village danced beneath them, the little ones chasing each other between the glowing rows while the drums beat soft and slow. But this year, as dusk settled over the terraced rice fields, the lanterns hung grey and dark, and not a single one would light.

The reason was a gentle one, and a little sad. Inside each paper lantern lived a shy Firefly Spirit, and it was their soft light that made the lanterns glow. Tonight, every one of them had slipped away to hide. They had flown up into the Whispering Bamboo Grove, deep among the dark stalks, far too timid to come out and shine.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper, who knew every story the mountains had ever told, called the two of you to her side. "You have wise heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more on a night like this than any lantern-pole. Will you climb to the grove and coax the firefly spirits gently home, so our festival can glow again?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a round paper lantern on a little handle, a ball of bright red thread, and a soft, sweet rice cake wrapped in a leaf. "Remember," she said, her eyes crinkling, "up in these hills we never win by being loud or strong. We win by being wise, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry tonight: Wisdom, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Dark Bamboo

The path wound up through the cool evening to the Whispering Bamboo Grove, where the tall green stalks clicked and swayed and whispered together in the wind. Inside it was dark and very, very still. Here and there a tiny light blinked on, then vanished, then blinked somewhere new, like stars that could not decide whether to come out. The firefly spirits were close. But they were shy, and the smallest sound sent them flickering away.

From the green shadows stepped a russet fox with bright, clever eyes and a single leaf balanced on his head. It was Kon the Fox, who loved a good game and a kind heart, and he gave you a slow, friendly wink, as if to say there was no hurry at all.

The spirits are timid, and timid friends cannot be chased. What gentle thing could you try? Could you move slowly and keep your voices soft? You carry a sweet rice cake to offer. Could you simply sit still and patient, and let the little lights choose to come to you?

So you grew quiet and calm, and waited. One small light drifted near, then hovered, then settled. Another followed, and another, until a whole soft cloud of golden fireflies floated all around you, warm against your cheeks, no longer the least bit afraid. "Well done," whispered Kon, his tail curling with pleasure. "They trust you now. They will follow where you lead."

Stop 2: The Lantern Path

The fireflies would come home with you, the fox explained, but only if every step felt safe. A long path of empty paper lanterns ran down the hillside to the village, and if you could light them in the right order, a gentle road of light would open up and lead the shy spirits all the way down.

But in what order? The lanterns stood in many sizes, some no bigger than a teacup and some as round as the moon, and your ball of red thread ran from one to the next, tying the whole line softly together.

How will you light them so the spirits never take fright? You might go from the smallest lantern to the very biggest, a path that grows as gently as the dawn. You might simply follow the red thread from lantern to lantern. Or you might ask Kon the Fox, who knows these paths well, for a quiet hint. What is your plan?

When you found the gentle order and touched each lantern alight, one after another, a soft golden road unrolled down the hill. The little fireflies bobbed along it in a happy ribbon of light, following close behind you, every step of the way a step they were not afraid to take.

Stop 3: The Great Lantern

At the top of the festival square stood the Great Lantern, taller than a grown-up and rounder than a barrel, the heart of the whole festival. To light it, the very shyest firefly of all had to fly up inside and shine. But this little spirit was the most timid of them all. It hung back at your shoulder, trembling, gazing up at the great dark lantern as if it were a mountain too high to climb.

This was never a fight, and there was nothing here to beat. The little firefly only needed to find, somewhere inside itself, a small and steady scrap of courage.

What could you say to help it feel brave? You might speak in the softest, calmest voice you have. You might tell it that you believe in it, and that you will be right here watching the whole time. You might gently remind it how brave it has already been. What do you try?

When you cheered it on, warm and unhurried, the little firefly drew in a tiny breath, lifted from your shoulder, and flew up into the dark. For a heartbeat there was nothing. Then the Great Lantern bloomed with light, the warmest and brightest of them all, and the little firefly glowed at its very heart, no longer afraid.

The Festival Glows

One by one, all across the village, every lantern caught the light and glowed a deep, happy gold, until the dark was chased clean away. The firefly spirits swirled out into the warm night air and danced, looping and spinning in bright circles above the rooftops, not a shy bone left among them.

The whole village burst into cheers and laughter, and the dancing began. The drums beat soft and warm, the lanterns swayed like a low sky full of small, kind moons, and Kon the Fox watched from a rooftop with his eyes shining.

And when at last the morning came, warm Amaterasu the Sun-Kami rose gently over the blossom mountains and smiled down upon the valley. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your wisdom, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the blossom mountains.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes finding tiny shy firefly spirits hiding in a dark bamboo grove at night, their glows barely flickering.



Two small heroes lighting a winding row of paper lanterns along a village path at night, each glowing warm gold as a firefly spirit settles in.



A friendly fox and two small heroes gently coaxing the shyest firefly spirit toward a great unlit festival lantern.



A whole village festival glowing with lit paper lanterns and swirling firefly spirits, two small heroes cheering, a silver moon above.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 2, updated 2026-06-03, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.